

The 15 Best Vegetables for Small Backyard Gardens

A free printable guide to the highest-yield, easiest-to-grow vegetables for small backyard plots — including spacing tips and which ones keep producing all season.

Small Space, Real Output

Most people overestimate how much land self-sufficiency actually takes. With the right layout — raised beds, vertical growing, succession planting, and smart companion pairings — a quarter acre or less can produce vegetables, fruit, herbs, and protein sources that meaningfully cut your grocery bill.

Why Most Backyard Gardens Fail

The usual approach is scattered: a few tomato plants here, a raised bed there, no real plan for preserving the harvest or extending the season. That's why so many backyard gardens produce a summer's worth of zucchini and nothing else useful. A self-sufficient backyard needs a system that covers growing, raising, and storing food year-round.

What Self-Sufficiency Actually Looks Like on a Small Lot

Think dense, layered growing beds instead of a sprawling row garden. Compact livestock options like rabbits or quail instead of cattle. Root cellaring, canning, and dehydrating instead of relying on a single harvest window. It's less about doing everything at once and more about stacking small, manageable systems that compound over a season.